NVIDIA Corporation

More cores or faster cores? The NVDA vs AMD agentic CPU debate

Maintain Rating: BUY | PO: 350.00 USD | Price: 207.29 USD

Emerging battle in $170bn server CPU market

Today NVDA provided its most detailed disclosure yet on its Vera CPU architecture, introducing a new framework for evaluating AI infrastructure: max single-threaded performance at scale. Vera combines 88 custom Olympus ARM-based cores, 1.2TB/s memory bandwidth and 3.4TB/s on-die fabric bandwidth, with NVDA arguing that agentic AI increasingly depends on CPU latency, memory responsiveness and GPU utilization. NVDA's choice of a monolithic compute die (which it claims provides scalable coherency) also stands in contrast to AMD's proven chiplet architecture. AMD's AI 2026 Day on Thursday (see our preview) provides the industry the first major opportunity for a public-technical response in a server CPU TAM that could 4x towards $170bn by 2030E (see our industry report).

NVDA: Faster agents beat more agents (# of cores)

NVDA's core argument is that agentic AI consists of repeated CPU↔GPU loops involving tool calls, code execution, retrieval and orchestration, where each step depends on completion of the previous one. In this framework, faster per-core performance directly improves agent response times, GPU utilization and overall AI-factory productivity. NVDA Vera CPU also benefits from "co-design" across six other AI building blocks including Rubin GPU, Groq LPX, Spectrum switches, and BlueField storage/NICs.

AMD: More agents beat faster agents

AMD argues production AI increasingly resembles a distributed software platform composed of databases, APIs, vector stores, orchestration engines, caches and middleware. In this environment, the primary constraint becomes the number of concurrent workflows that can be sustained inside a fixed power envelope. AMD estimates EPYC 9965 (Turin) delivers ~2.4x the rack-level throughput of NVIDIA's Vera baseline in a modeled 100kW deployment, with EPYC 6 (Venice) projected at ~3.3x.

A parallel debate: x86 versus ARM

The CPU discussion extends beyond core counts into software ecosystems. NVDA's position implies ISA becomes secondary if superior microarchitecture delivers better agent performance. AMD and INTC are likely to argue that agentic AI increasingly intersects with enterprise software stacks, where x86 benefits from decades of optimization, validation and compatibility across databases, middleware, security platforms and enterprise applications. As AI expands from model inference into enterprise workflows, software incumbency could become an important differentiator.

Our view: Defining the next CPU KPI

The key question for investors is whether agentic AI is primarily constrained by **time-to-complete an agent** or **number-of-agents-per-rack**. NVDA's framework is rooted in latency, per-thread progress, and GPU utilization. AMD's framework is rooted in concurrency, throughput, and service density. Our expectation is that AMD's Thursday event will be less about benchmark comparisons and more about establishing the industry's preferred metric.

Refer to important disclosures on page 5 to 8. Analyst Certification on page 4. Price Objective Basis/Risk on page 3.

22 July 2026

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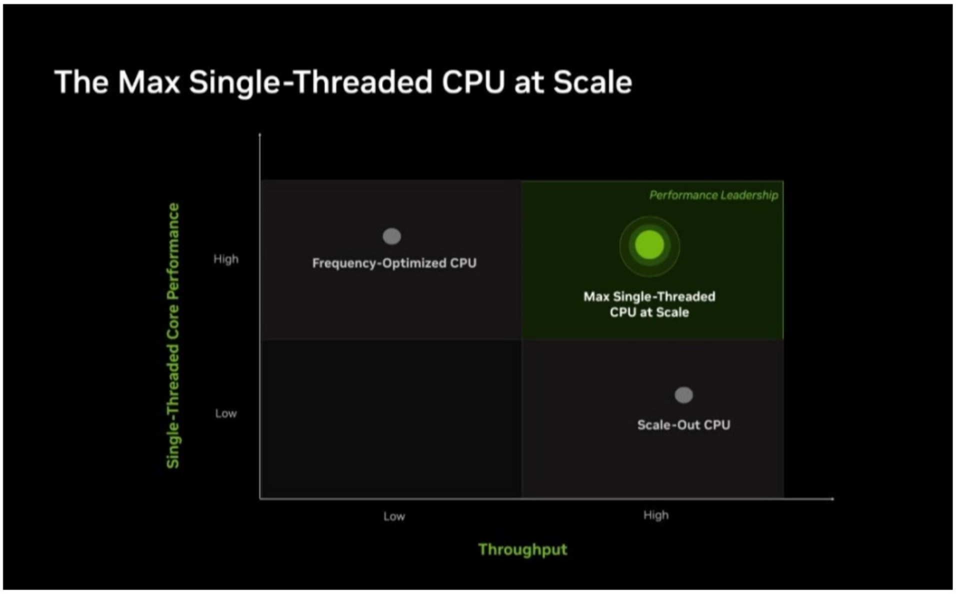
Stock Data

Price	207.29 USD
Price Objective	350.00 USD
Date Established	20-May-2026
Investment Opinion	C-1-7
52-Week Range	164.07 USD - 236.54 USD
Mrkt Val (mn) / Shares Out (mn)	5,157,375 USD / 24,880.0
Free Float	96.2%
Average Daily Value (mn)	30162.66 USD
BofA Ticker / Exchange	NVDA / NAS
Bloomberg / Reuters	NVDA US / NVDA.OQ
ROE (2027E)	95.9%
Net Dbt to Eqty (Jan-2026A)	-1.4%

Exhibit 1: NVDA argues Vera provides the max single threaded performance critical for agentic AI
Single-threaded core versus throughput quadrant and Vera CPU positioning



Source: NVDA

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Glossary:

AI – Artificial Intelligence

AMD – Advanced Micro Devices

API – Application Programming Interface

ARM – Advanced RISC Machines

CPU – Central Processing Unit

GPU – Graphics Processing Unit

INTC – Intel Corporation

ISA – Instruction Set Architecture

KPI – Key Performance Indicator

kW – Kilowatt

LPX – Groq's Language Processing Unit variant

NIC – Network Interface Card

NVDA – NVIDIA

TAM – Total Addressable Market

TB/s – Terabytes per second

Exhibit 2: Companies mentioned
Companies mentioned in this report

BofA Ticker	Bloomberg ticker	Company name	Price	Rating
NVDA	NVDA US	NVIDIA	US$ 207.29	C-1-7
AMD	AMD US	Advanced Micro	US$ 544.43	C-1-9
ARM	ARM US	Arm Holdings	US$ 289.73	C-2-9
INTC	INTC US	Intel	US$ 105.45	C-1-9

Source: BofA Global Research

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Price objective basis & risk

Advanced Micro Devices, Inc (AMD)

Our $620 PO is based on 47x our 2027E non-GAAP EPS. Our PO basis is now towards middle/upper range of historical 13x-58x, but is well supported by AMD's 50%+ annual EPS CAGR potential and its AI CPU/GPU share gain potentials, modestly offset by slower growth in cyclical PC/embedded/console markets.

Downside risks: 1) Execution on first rack-scale product (MI400 Series), 2) Timing/Magnitude of Middle East AI Projects, 3) Lumpy nature of consumer and enterprise spending that could create delays in acceptance and success of new products, 4) High reliance on one outsourced manufacturing partner, 5) Maturity of current game console cycle.

Upside risks are greater share gain potential in the PC and server processor market against competitors.

Arm Holdings (ARM)

Our $460 PO is based on conceptual sum-of-parts valuation that values the IP business at $342 (2.5x CY30E PEG, discounted back 2 years) and the chiplet business at $118 (31x CY30E PE, discounted back 2 years), with both multiples in-line with competitive peer range/average. Our PO implies 130x total company CY28E PE which is still within ARM's historical 35x-147x range, given longer-term data center content and silicon/chiplet (AGI CPU) opportunities, offset by high SoftBank dependence and opex ramp.

Upside risks: 1) better than expected smartphone/PC/server unit shipment, 2) faster adoption of higher-royalty rate v9 and CSS IP at customers, 3) faster share gains and ramp of AGI CPU chiplet lineup, 4) further proliferation of AI data centers and hyperscale-specific custom products, 5) Qualcomm/Nuvia content expansion post-settlement, 6) small floating volume.

Downside risks: 1) historically cyclical nature of semiconductor units, 2) high exposure to mature smartphone market, 3) competition against established x86 and other custom Arm-based CPU offerings in the data center, 4) emerging competition from RISC-V in low-end consumer markets, 5) rising geopolitical tensions and deterioration of Arm China relationship, 6) ongoing Qualcomm/Nuvia litigation, 7) small trading float.

Intel (INTC)

Our $160 price objective is based on 31x CY30E EPS power of $6+, discounted back two years, given the company's key server CPU and external foundry wafer/packaging opportunities that extend far out. Our PO implies 10.7x our total company 2028E EV/S which is well above historical 1.7x-4x range but we view as appropriate given increasing server CPU and external foundry opportunity, offset by near-/medium-term manufacturing ramp-up uncertainties.

Upside risks to our price objective are 1) key external foundry packaging/wafer deals that could significantly boost sales/utilization, 2) greater than expected yields/ramps at 18A and upcoming 14A nodes, resulting in greater GM/utilization profile, 3) stronger than expected PC market from Windows 10 refresh or AI uplift, 4) geopolitical tensions boosting sentiment for domestic manufacturing asset.

Downside risks to our price objective are 1) lower than yield/ramp at Intel Foundry, particularly for its new 18A and upcoming 14A nodes, 2) lack of material external foundry customer in wafer processing, 3) weaker-than-expected trends in a mature PC market, which is largest revenue generator for Intel, 4) accelerated share loss to major CPU competitors.

NVIDIA Corporation (NVDA)
Our $350 PO is based on 26x CY27E PE ex cash, within NVDA's historical 25x-56x forward year PE range, which we believe is justified by NVDA's leading share in fast-growing AI compute/networking markets, offset by lumpiness in global AI projects, cyclical gaming market, and concerns around access to power.

Downside risks are: 1) weakness in consumer driven gaming market, 2) Competition with major public firms, internal cloud projects and other private companies in AI and accelerated computing markets, 3) Larger than expected impact from restrictions on compute shipments to China, or additional restrictions placed on activity in the region, 4) Lumpy and unpredictable sales in new enterprise, data center, and autos markets, 5) Potential for decelerating capital returns, and 6) Enhanced government scrutiny of NVDA's dominant market position in AI chips.

Analyst Certification

I, Vivek Arya, hereby certify that the views expressed in this research report accurately reflect my personal views about the subject securities and issuers. I also certify that no part of my compensation was, is, or will be, directly or indirectly, related to the specific recommendations or view expressed in this research report.

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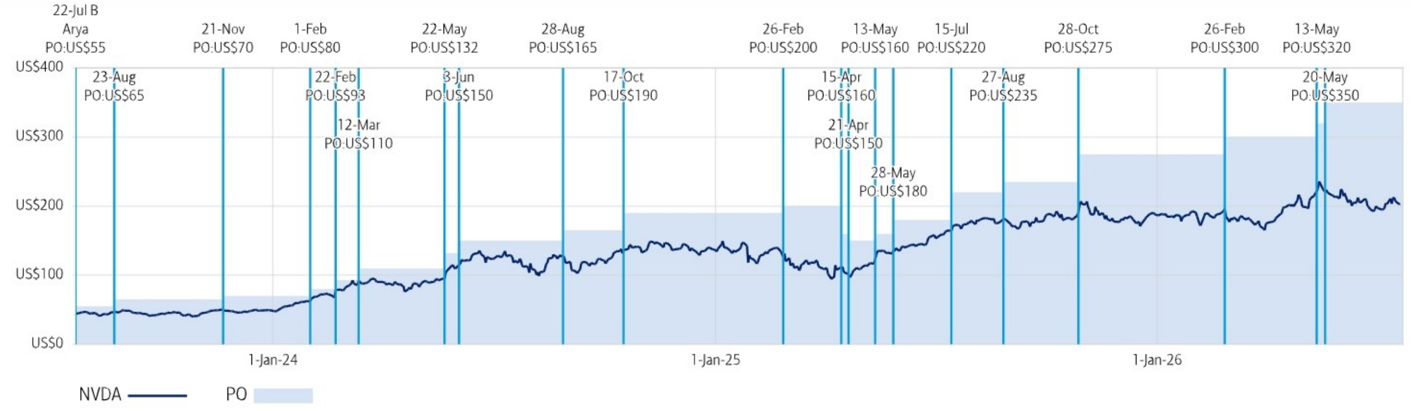
Disclosures

Important Disclosures

NVIDIA (NVDA) Price Chart



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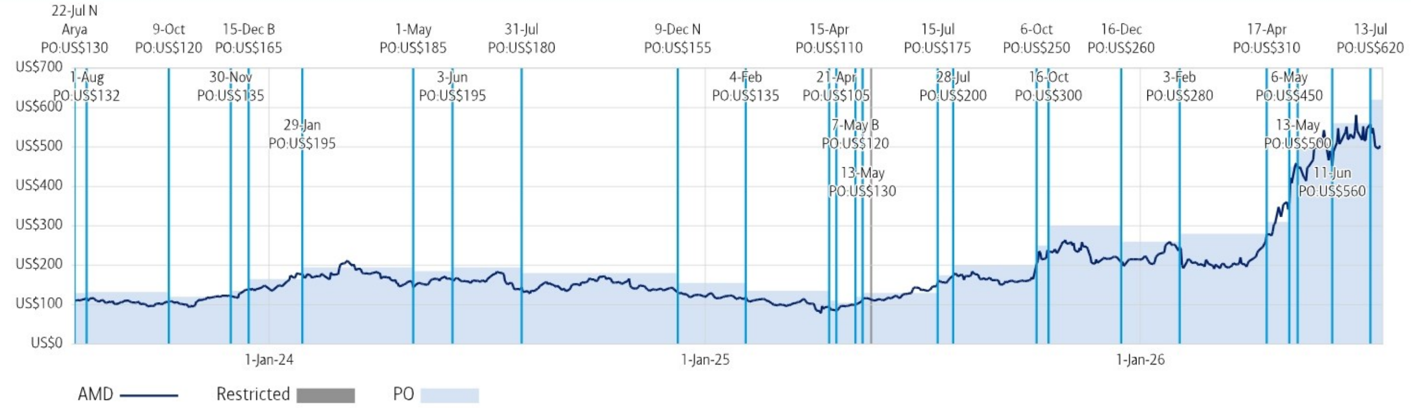
Advanced Micro (AMD) Price Chart



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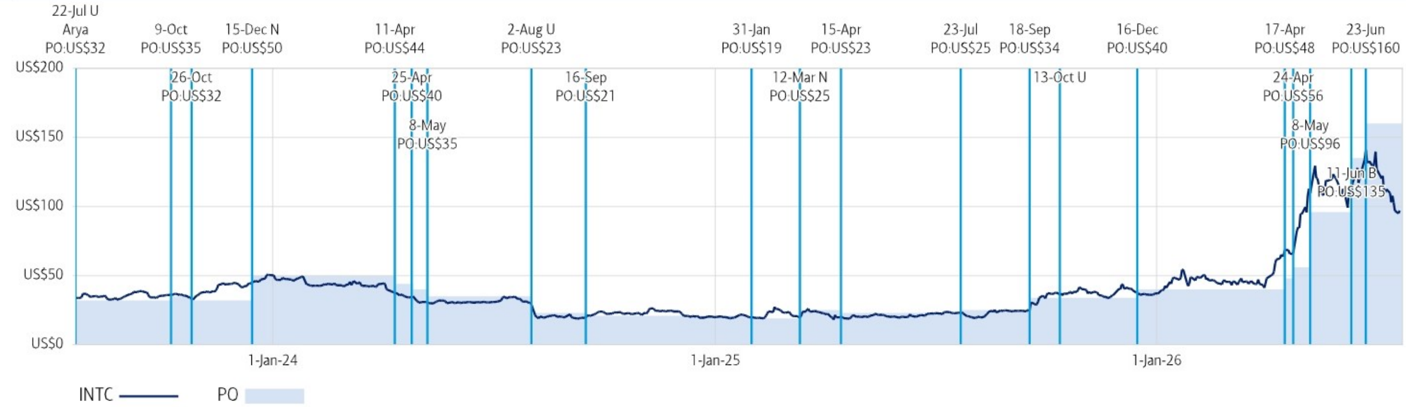
Intel (INTC) Price Chart



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Equity Investment Rating Distribution: Technology Group (as of 30 Jun 2026)

Coverage Universe	Count	Percent	Inv. Banking Relationships [R1]	Count	Percent
Buy	243	60.60%	Buy	123	50.62%
Hold	87	21.70%	Hold	45	51.72%
Sell	71	17.71%	Sell	21	29.58%

Equity Investment Rating Distribution: Global Group (as of 30 Jun 2026)

Coverage Universe	Count	Percent	Inv. Banking Relationships [R1]	Count	Percent
Buy	1987	56.11%	Buy	1190	59.89%
Hold	797	22.51%	Hold	496	62.23%
Sell	757	21.38%	Sell	391	51.65%

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Underperform	N/A	≥ 20%

[R2]Ratings dispersions may vary from time to time where BofA Global Research believes it better reflects the investment prospects of stocks in a Coverage Cluster.

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